



NODUS · COMPLETE VAULT GUIDE

Academic Research

Turn a scholarly corpus into traceable ideas, debates, gaps and writing.

The Academic vault is designed for literature reviews, theses and research projects. It links every interpretation back to a work, passage and citation while supporting discovery, synthesis and long-form writing.

VERSION	Nodus 4.1
UPDATED	14 August 2026
AUDIENCE	Researchers, doctoral candidates, students and evidence-led writers.

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Core operation, configuration and the complete vault workflow.

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PART I · FOUNDATION

Core Nodus workflow

Start here if Nodus is new to you. These chapters explain what a vault is, how to move through the application, how sources remain traceable, when a model is optional and how to keep a recoverable copy of the work.

START HERE

1 Welcome to Nodus

Nodus is a local-first desktop workspace for research, teaching and study. Work is organised into focused vaults that share one private engine.

A vault is an independent workspace for one project, course, family or dataset. Changing the vault changes the navigation and assistant context, while the database, indexes and preserved files stay on the computer. Accounts are optional, and model-assisted features run only after a provider or local model has been configured.

WHERE TO FIND IT

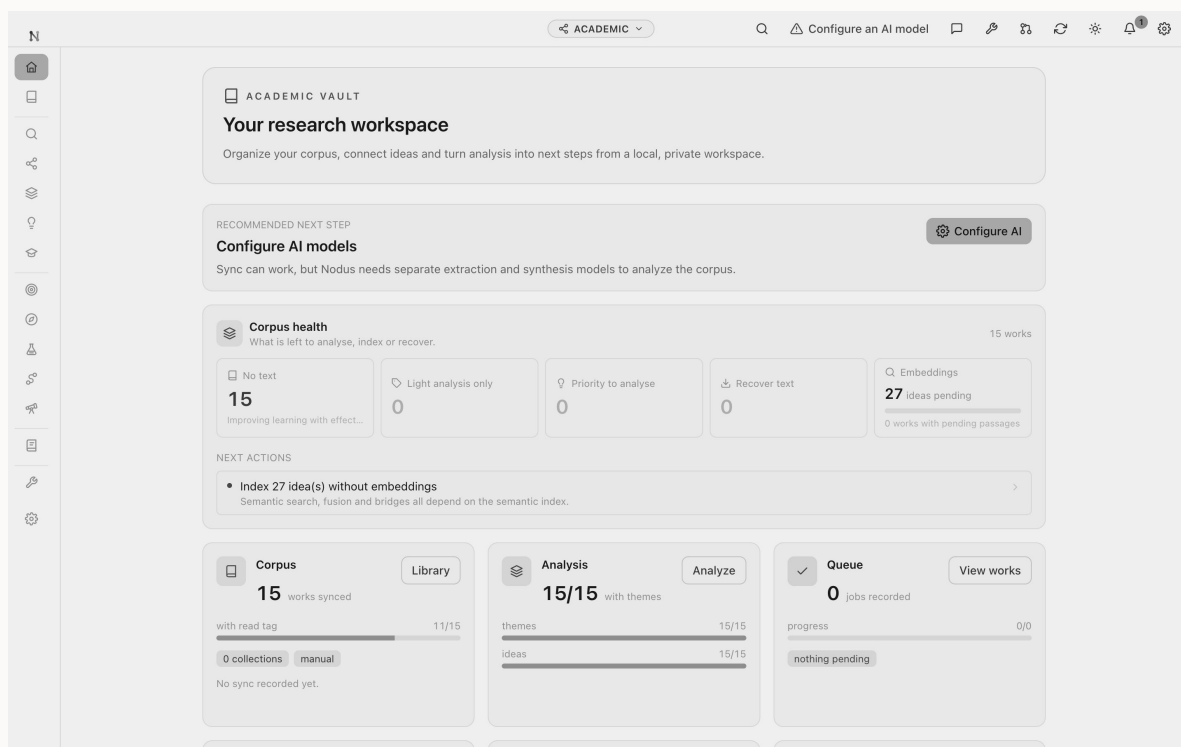
Install Nodus, then open the application

STEP BY STEP

1. Download the package for macOS, Windows or Linux from the Nodus release page and complete the installer.
2. Launch Nodus and complete the short setup: appearance, optional Nodi assistant and the introductory tour.
3. Create the vault that matches the work you are starting, give it a clear name and remain on Home while you learn the layout.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use one vault per coherent project, course, family or dataset.
- Start with a small set of real material that you are allowed to process.



Welcome to Nodus in the Nodus desktop application

START HERE

2 Create and switch vaults

Create independent workspaces and move between them without mixing their context.

The vault switcher is the boundary between projects. Each vault has its own notes, analysis and domain records, while the global Library can link the same source into compatible vaults without duplicating it.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Application header → vault name and icon

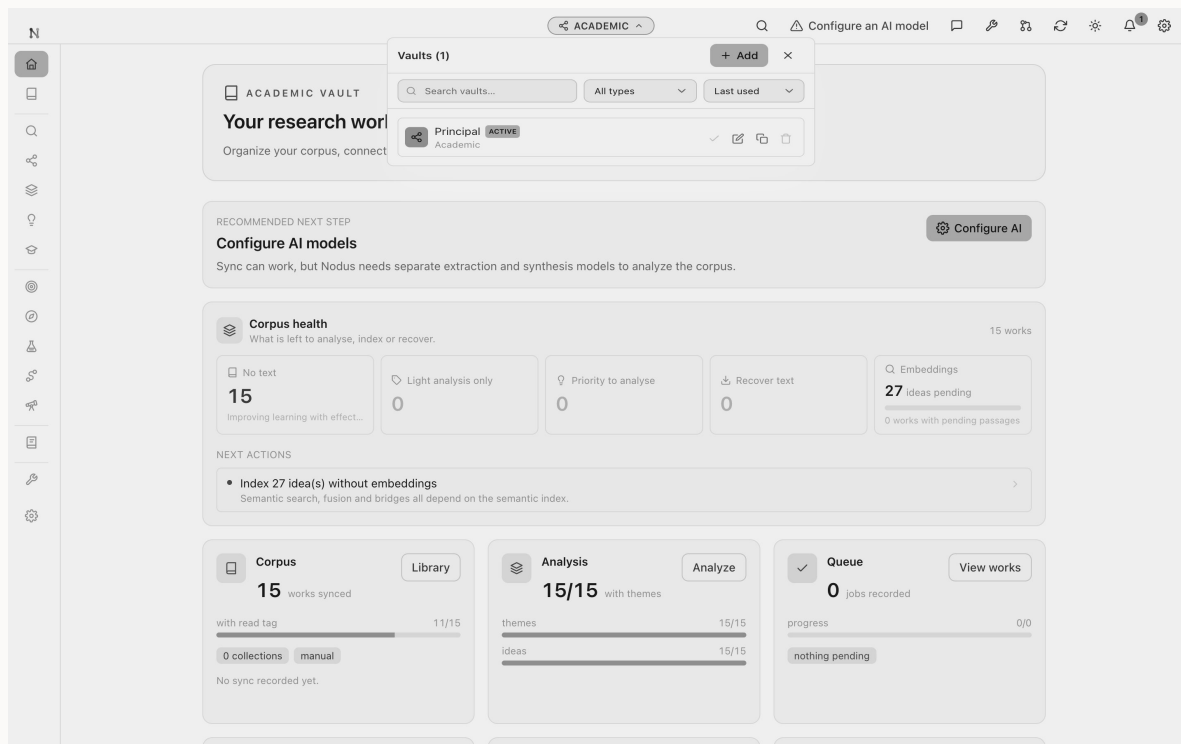
STEP BY STEP

1. Select the current vault name in the centre of the application header, then choose the action to create a vault.
2. Enter a descriptive name, select the correct vault type and read the explanation of the workflow it enables before confirming.
3. Open the same switcher whenever you need another project; choose a vault and wait for its Home view to appear.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use explicit names such as 'MA thesis - memory' or 'Biology 2026'.

- Create a new vault instead of changing the meaning of a mature workspace.



Create and switch vaults in the Nodus desktop application

ESSENTIALS

3 Navigation and global search

The sidebar exposes the workflow for the active vault; search retrieves material across the relevant local index.

The narrow left sidebar contains the active vault's tools. Hover an icon to read its label. The magnifying-glass button opens search, while the vault button in the header changes workspace. Keyword search works immediately; semantic retrieval also requires an embedding model.

WHERE TO FIND IT

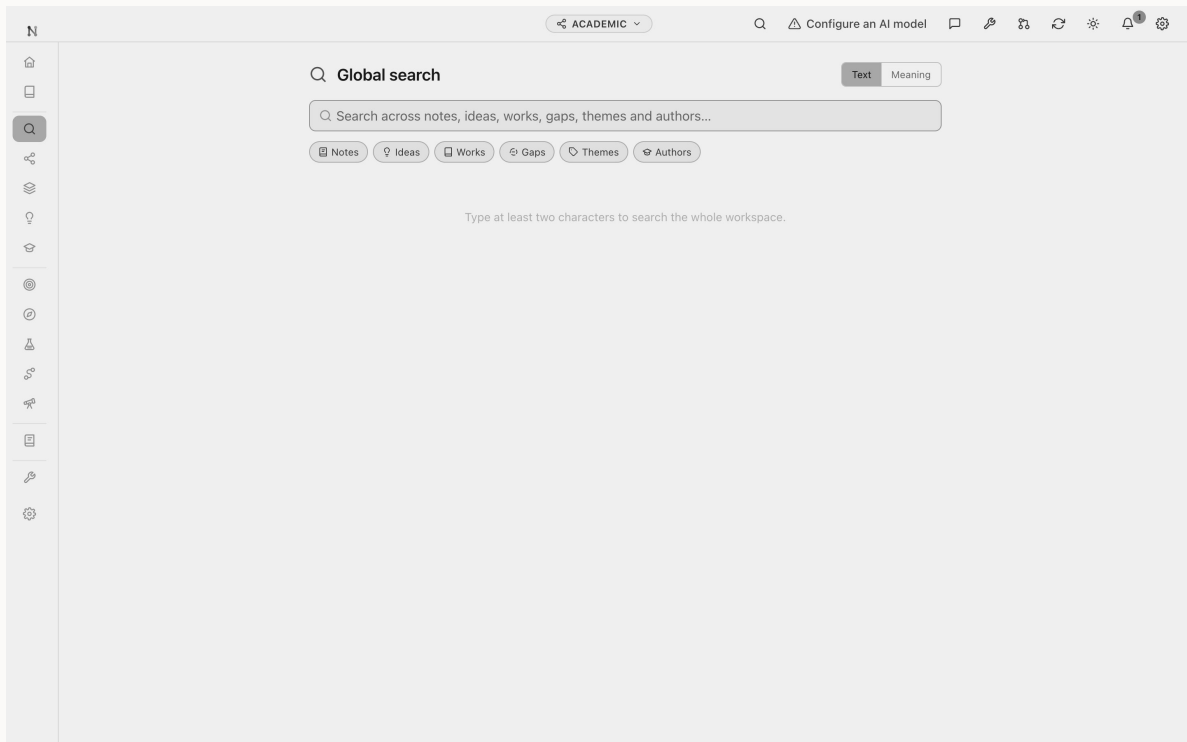
Left sidebar → magnifying-glass icon

STEP BY STEP

1. Move the pointer over sidebar icons until the label for the section you need appears, then select it; the active icon receives the vault colour.
2. Open Search and enter a title, name, quotation or concept of at least two meaningful characters.
3. Apply a type or scope filter when available, open a result and follow its source link to the original document, record, person or note.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Search for concepts as well as exact titles.
- Rebuild an index from Settings if recently imported content does not appear.



Navigation and global search in the Nodus desktop application

ESSENTIALS

4 Library, sources and reader

Keep preserved originals beside clean reading copies, citations, highlights and extracted evidence.

The cross-vault Library can mirror Zotero, import RIS, BibTeX and CSL JSON, or accept files directly. Nodus preserves the original attachment and creates searchable derivatives. Compatible sources can be linked to several vaults without copying the original.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Nodus → Library, sources and reader

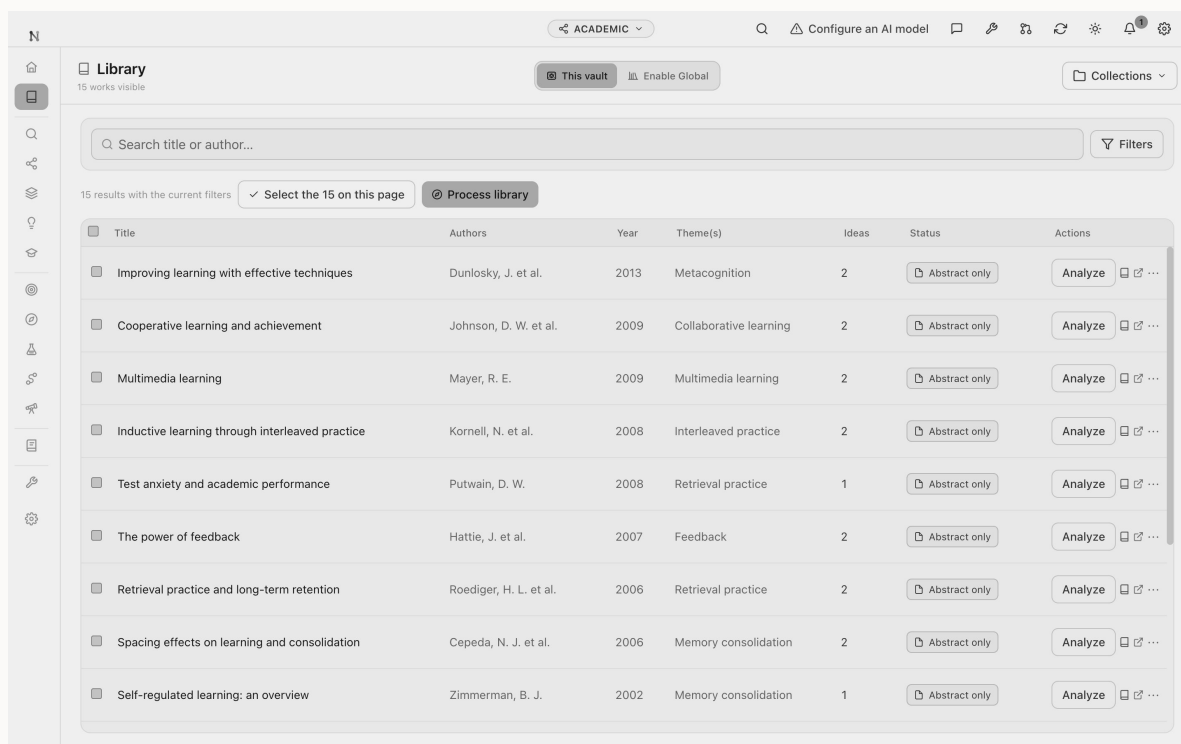
STEP BY STEP

1. Open Library and add a local file, import bibliographic data or connect Zotero.
2. Place the item in a collection and add useful tags; wait for extraction and indexing to finish.

3. Open the item, choose the clean reading copy or preserved original, then highlight passages and link the item into the active vault.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep the preserved original for page-accurate verification.
- Treat automatically extracted text and metadata as a first pass that may need correction.



Library, sources and reader in the Nodus desktop application

CONFIGURATION

5 AI providers and task models

Bring your own cloud key or use compatible local models, with a different model for each task.

Nodus can be used without a model for deterministic organisation and editing. Features that generate, explain or synthesise text need a configured provider or compatible local endpoint. Provider keys are stored in the operating-system keychain, and task models let extraction, chat and reports use different choices.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Left sidebar → Settings → AI and providers

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings and find the AI provider section. Choose a cloud provider or enter the address of a compatible local endpoint.
2. Enter the required credential, use the connection test and resolve any error before continuing.
3. Assign a model to each available task, save the settings and test it on a small, non-sensitive source.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A local model improves privacy but may require more memory and time.
- Review every generated claim against its linked evidence.

CONFIGURATION

6 Privacy, backups and recovery

Protect local work with a verified backup and understand exactly when network services are used.

Vault databases, indexes and library files are local by default. Backups can include all vaults and the shared Library. Nodus reports backup health and creates protected recovery copies before major migrations.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Nodus → Privacy, backups and recovery

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, choose a backup destination and enable automatic backups.
2. Run a manual backup, then use verification to confirm that its manifest and files are readable.
3. Review the privacy notice for each optional online feature before sending content.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Store backups on a different physical device or a trusted encrypted location.
- Do not treat sync as a backup; keep versioned recovery copies.

CONFIGURATION

7 Toolkit and integrations

Convert, protect, translate, OCR and present documents, or connect Zotero, Word, MCP clients and Nodus Server.

Toolkit contains file utilities shared by every vault. Integrations are optional: Zotero supplies bibliographic material, Word can use selected Nodus context, MCP exposes approved local tools, and Nodus Server

publishes a selected copy rather than the source vault.

WHERE TO FIND IT

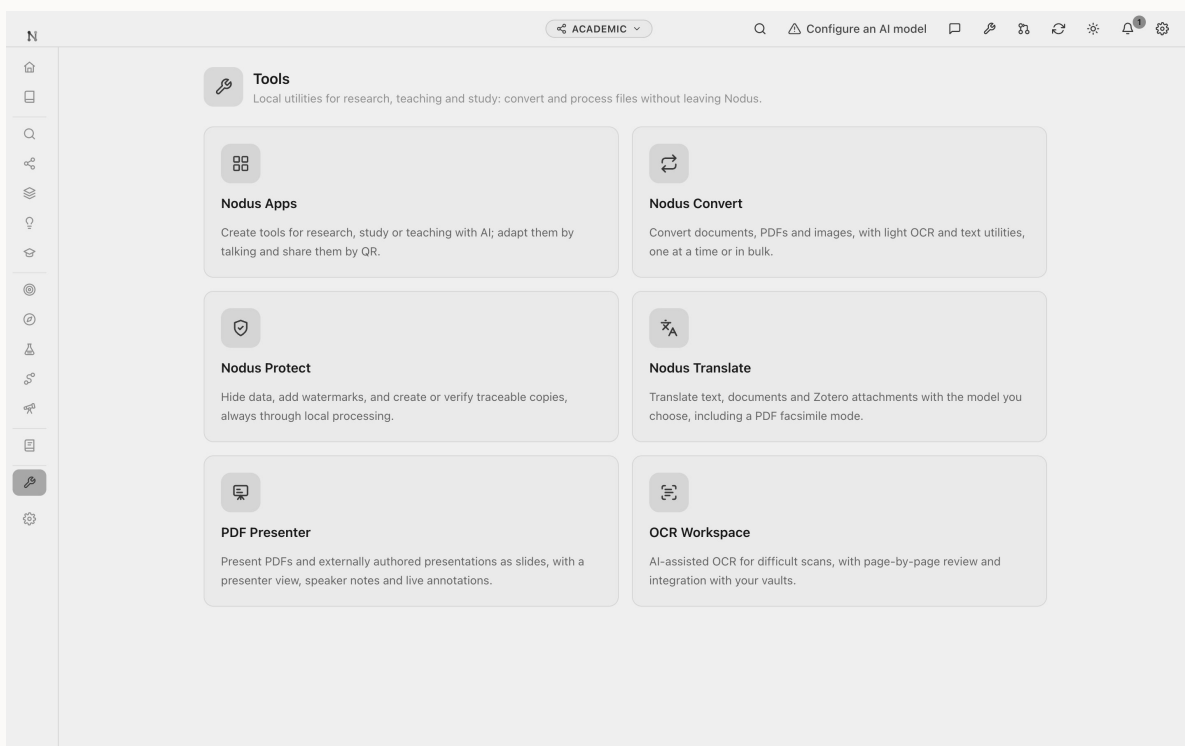
Left sidebar → wrench icon → Toolkit

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Toolkit and choose Convert, Protect, Translate, OCR Workspace or PDF Presenter.
2. Select a file from disk or a compatible vault source, then review every output option and destination.
3. For an integration, enable only the connector you need and test it with a non-sensitive file before using project material.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Permanent redaction in Protect is local and irreversible in the exported copy.
- Published server spaces should contain only material intended for their readers.

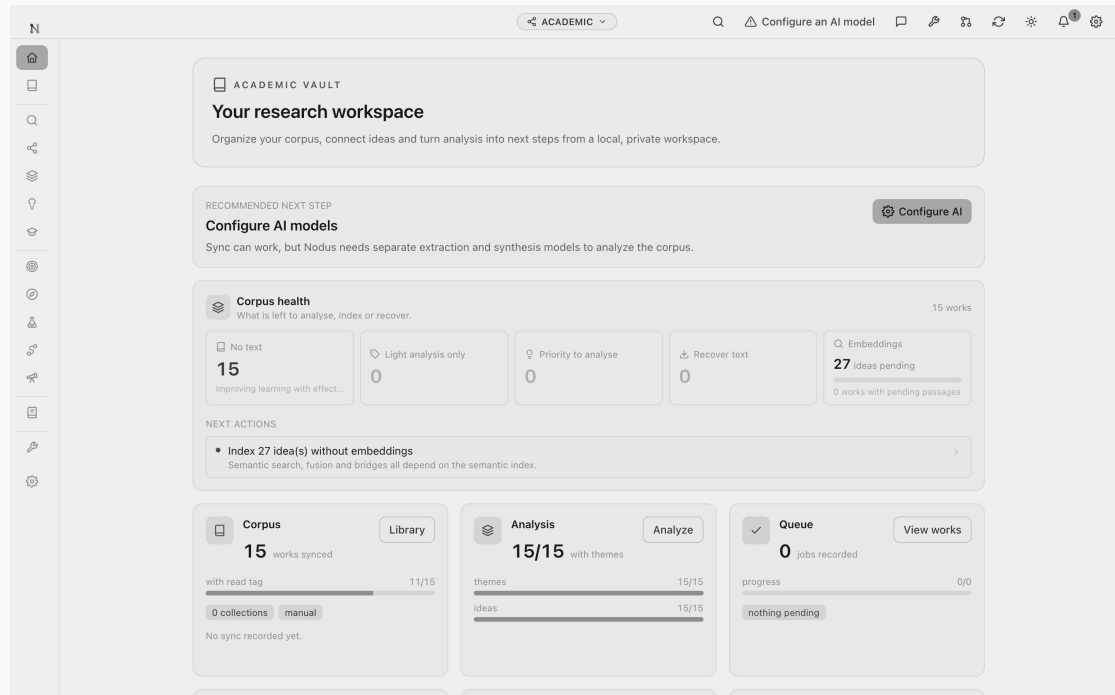


Toolkit and integrations in the Nodus desktop application

PART II · VAULT GUIDE

Complete Academic Research workflow

The Academic vault is designed for literature reviews, theses and research projects. It links every interpretation back to a work, passage and citation while supporting discovery, synthesis and long-form writing.



Academic Research vault home in the Nodus desktop application

ORIENTATION

1 Home and research status

Read the health of the corpus and jump to the most useful next action.

Home combines corpus totals, recent activity, analysis progress and shortcuts. It is a dashboard, not a separate store: every card opens the underlying view.

WHERE TO FIND IT

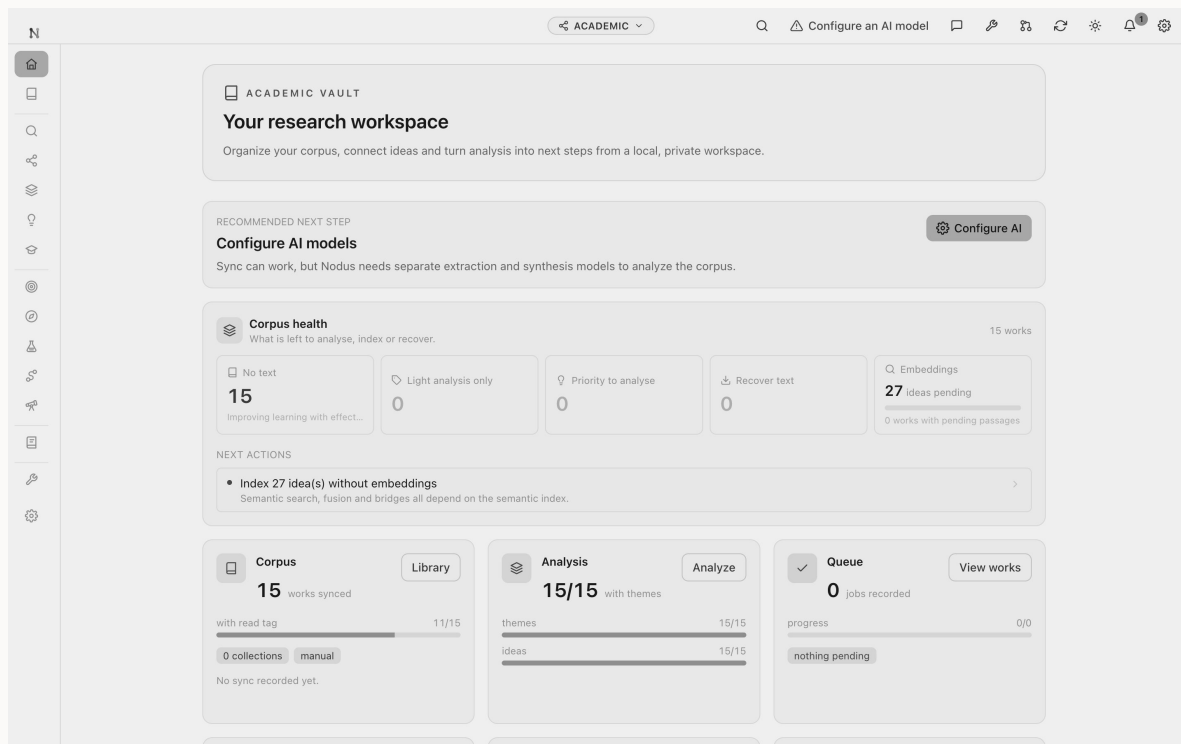
Academic Research vault → Home and research status

STEP BY STEP

1. Check the corpus and idea counts after importing sources.
2. Review processing or coverage warnings before starting synthesis.
3. Use Recent activity or a recommended next step to resume work.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A small, carefully scoped corpus often produces better analysis than an indiscriminate import.



Home and research status in the Nodus desktop application

EXPLORE

2 Search

Search works, ideas and authors with exact and semantic retrieval.

Results preserve the entity type and source context. Semantic search is valuable when the wording in the corpus differs from the question.

WHERE TO FIND IT

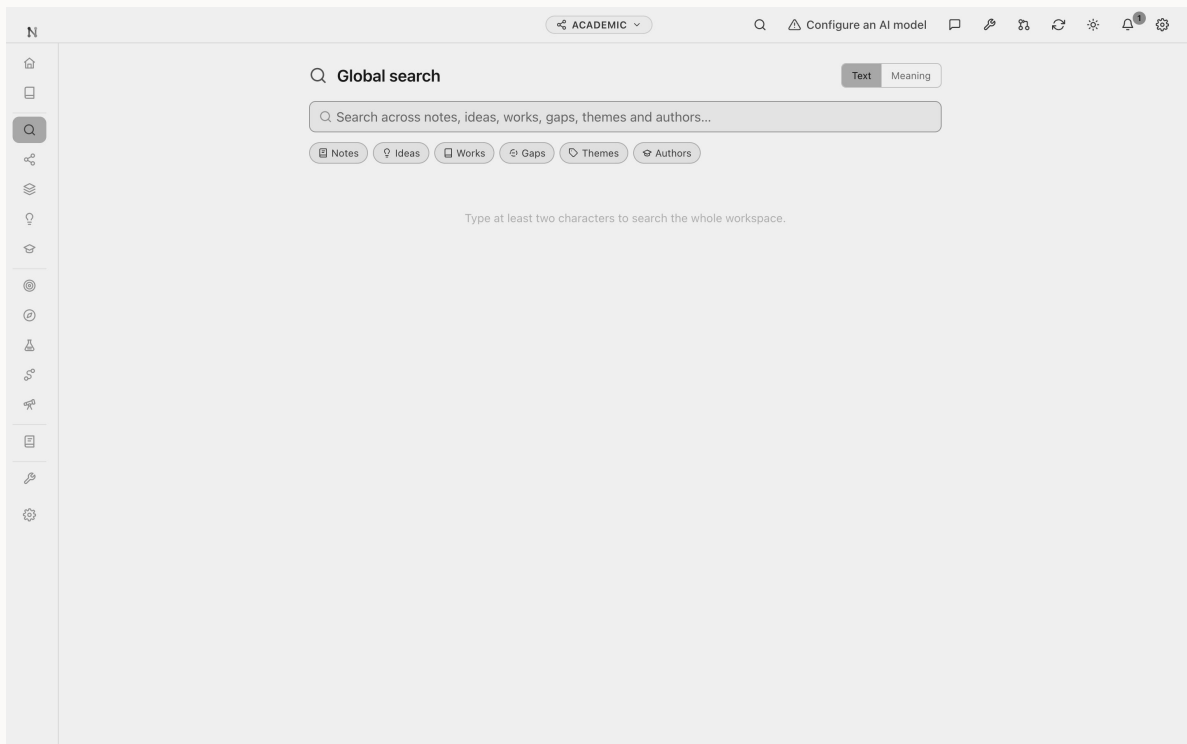
Academic Research vault → Search

STEP BY STEP

1. Enter a title fragment, author, quotation or concept.
2. Compare idea, author and work results rather than opening only the first hit.
3. Open the source record and verify the relevant passage.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use filters or a narrower query when the corpus spans unrelated fields.



Search in the Nodus desktop application

EXPLORE

3 Library and corpus

Build the evidence base from Zotero or local sources and decide what belongs in this vault.

The Library stores bibliographic metadata, attachments and searchable text. Linking an item to the vault places it in the academic corpus; removing the link does not destroy the global source.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Academic Research vault → Library and corpus

STEP BY STEP

1. Import or sync sources and inspect title, authors, year, identifiers and attachment status.
2. Link relevant items into the vault and organise them with collections and tags.
3. Open the reader to highlight, annotate and confirm page mappings.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Resolve duplicate records before analysis so one source is not counted twice.

EXPLORE

4 Knowledge graph

See themes, ideas and typed relations as an interactive research map.

Nodes represent research entities and edges express relations such as support, contrast or application. Presets and filters help move from a corpus overview to a focused question.

WHERE TO FIND IT

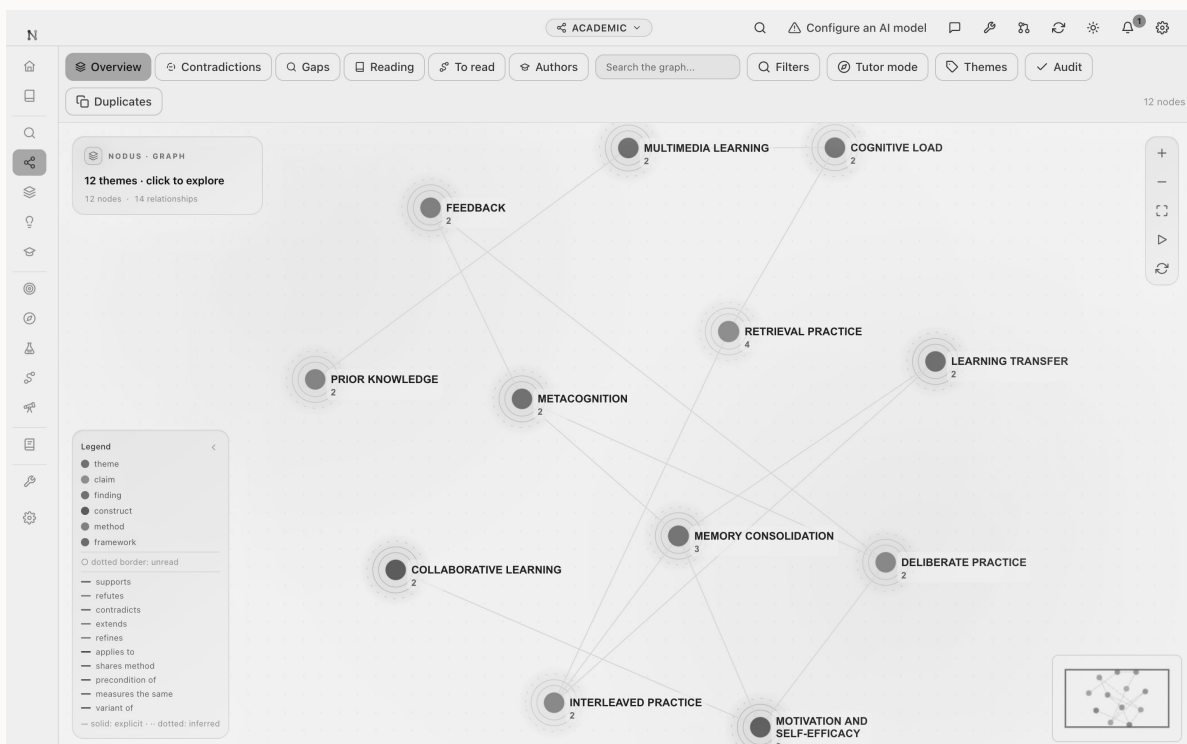
Academic Research vault → Knowledge graph

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a graph preset or filter by theme, author or relation type.
2. Select a node to inspect its evidence and immediate neighbourhood.
3. Open a connected source before accepting the interpretation represented by an edge.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use the graph to generate questions, not as proof by itself.



Knowledge graph in the Nodus desktop application

EXPLORE

5 Argument map

Arrange claims and evidence into an explicit structure for a paper or chapter.

Argument maps make the role of each claim visible: thesis, support, objection, reply or evidence. Connections remain inspectable and can be reorganised as the argument develops.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Academic Research vault → Argument map

STEP BY STEP

1. Create or open a map for one defensible research question.
2. Add claims from extracted ideas or write a clearly labelled working claim.
3. Connect supporting evidence, objections and replies, then check every leaf node for a source.

GOOD PRACTICE

- If a claim has no evidence or inferential bridge, the map has found a writing problem early.

EXPLORE

6 Ideas

Review extracted claims, findings, methods and definitions with their exact evidence.

Ideas are structured interpretations of passages, not detached summaries. Each one records its type, source and supporting excerpt and can participate in themes and relations.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Academic Research vault → Ideas

STEP BY STEP

1. Filter by type or theme and open an idea.
2. Read the verbatim evidence and page reference.
3. Correct the label or relation when the extraction overstates the source.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Prefer concise idea labels that make one testable or attributable claim.

Idea ↑	Type	No. of works	No. of connections	Confidence	THEMES
● A feeling of fluency can mislead Immediate ease during study does not necessarily predict durable retention.	finding	1	1	0.82	Metacognition
● Active retrieval beats rereading The effort of retrieving from memory leaves a more durable trace than repeated, passive exposure.	claim	1	3	0.84	Retrieval practice
● Attainable goals build self-efficacy Breaking a complex task into proximal accomplishments provides mastery experiences that strengthen confidence.	method	1	1	0.83	Motivation and self-effic...
● Blocked practice overstates mastery Grouping identical problems increases apparent fluency but reduces the need to choose a strategy.	claim	1	1	0.80	Interleaved practice
● Deliberate practice targets specific weaknesses Expert improvement requires tasks designed to overcome specific aspects of current performance.	method	1	3	0.91	Deliberate practice
● Expert improvement requires feedback and repetition Focused attempts need immediate feedback and repeated opportunities for correction.	claim	1	2	0.88	Deliberate practice
● Feedback closes the gap to the goal Feedback is useful when it clarifies the goal, current progress, and the next step.	framework	1	3	0.91	Feedback
● Generating the answer improves recall over reading it Actively producing an answer yields better recall than reading that same answer already given.	finding	1	2	0.83	Retrieval practice

Ideas in the Nodus desktop application

EXPLORE

7 Authors

Compare an author's works, ideas and position within the corpus.

Author profiles aggregate only what the active corpus supports. They help distinguish an author's documented stance from a general reputation.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Academic Research vault → Authors

STEP BY STEP

1. Open an author and review works included in the corpus.
2. Compare their idea set and position map with adjacent authors.
3. Return to source passages before describing disagreement or influence.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Do not infer an author's complete position from an incomplete corpus.

ANALYSE

8 Immersion

Follow a guided, audio-capable journey through a central research question.

Immersion sequences evidence stations, commentary and a final check. It is designed for focused orientation, not as a replacement for reading the sources.

WHERE TO FIND IT

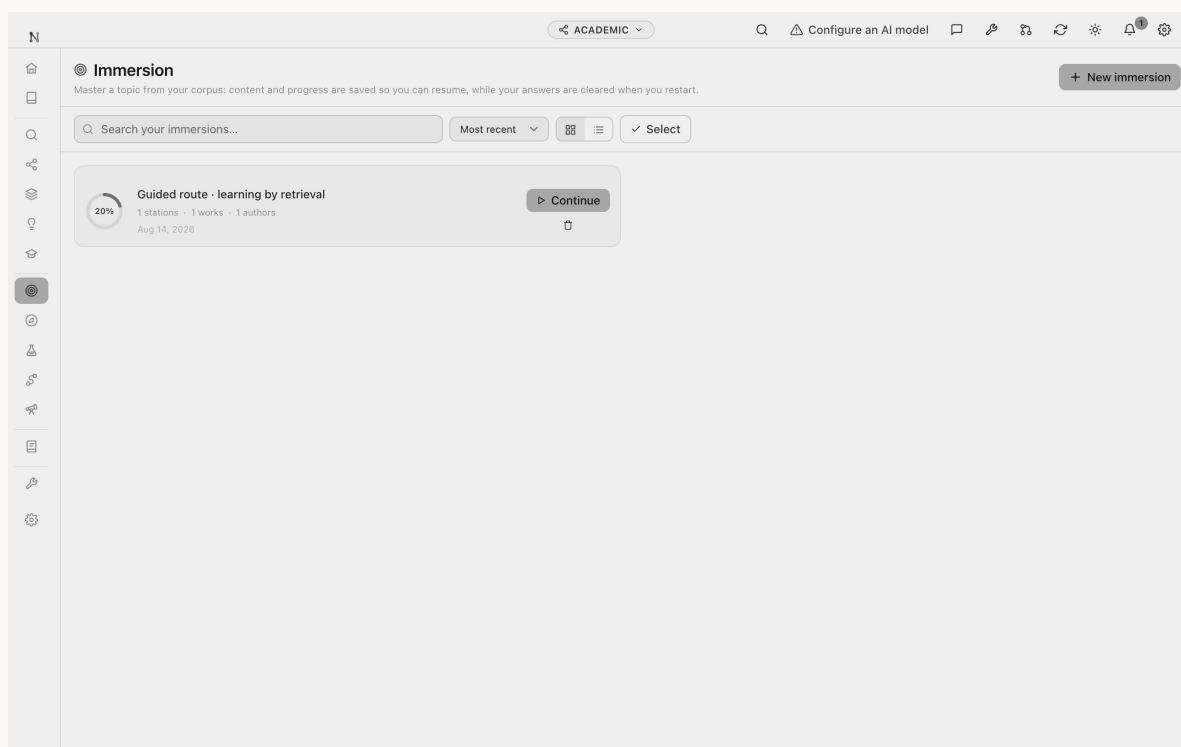
Academic Research vault → Immersion

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose an available immersion and review its duration and sources.
2. Move through each station, pausing to inspect quotations and context.
3. Complete the final question and save follow-up notes.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use headphones for audio, but keep citations visible for verification.



Immersion in the Nodus desktop application

ANALYSE

9 Research gaps

Distinguish unanswered questions from places where the current corpus is merely incomplete.

A gap records available evidence, what remains missing and candidate directions. It is a research prompt whose strength depends on corpus coverage.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Academic Research vault → Research gaps

STEP BY STEP

1. Open a gap and read the evidence already present.
2. Examine what would close the gap and whether the scope is explicit.
3. Search external catalogues for candidate sources, then update the gap after importing them.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Phrase conclusions as 'gap in this corpus' until a broader search supports a field-level claim.

ANALYSE

10 Debates

Compare opposed or qualified positions without flattening their evidence.

Debate views group claims by stance and show the works behind them. Nuance, boundary conditions and methodological differences can matter more than a simple pro/con split.

WHERE TO FIND IT

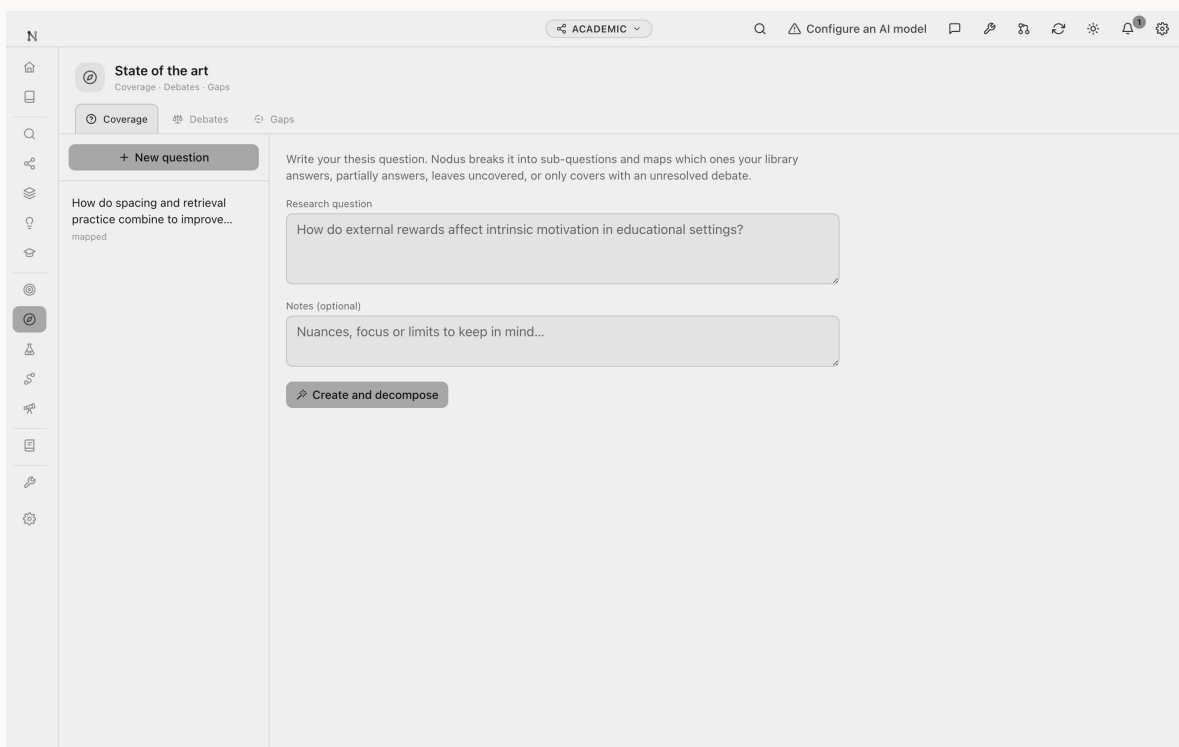
Academic Research vault → Debates

STEP BY STEP

1. Open a debate and identify the precise proposition under dispute.
2. Compare the strongest evidence on each side and inspect source passages.
3. Record qualifications or a synthesis that explains when each position holds.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Do not count papers as votes; compare relevance, method and evidential strength.



Debates in the Nodus desktop application

ANALYSE

11 Coverage analysis

Measure how well the corpus supports important themes and questions.

Coverage highlights overrepresented and under-supported areas. It helps prioritise reading and makes literature-review boundaries explicit.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Academic Research vault → Coverage analysis

STEP BY STEP

1. Select a theme or question and inspect its linked works and ideas.
2. Review missing perspectives, dates, methods or populations.
3. Turn a weakness into a targeted search query or reading task.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Coverage is relative to your project question, not a universal completeness score.

ANALYSE

12 Hypotheses

Turn patterns in the corpus into falsifiable propositions and test designs.

A hypothesis combines a statement, supporting ideas, risks and a proposed test. Keeping these fields separate prevents plausible speculation from masquerading as evidence.

WHERE TO FIND IT

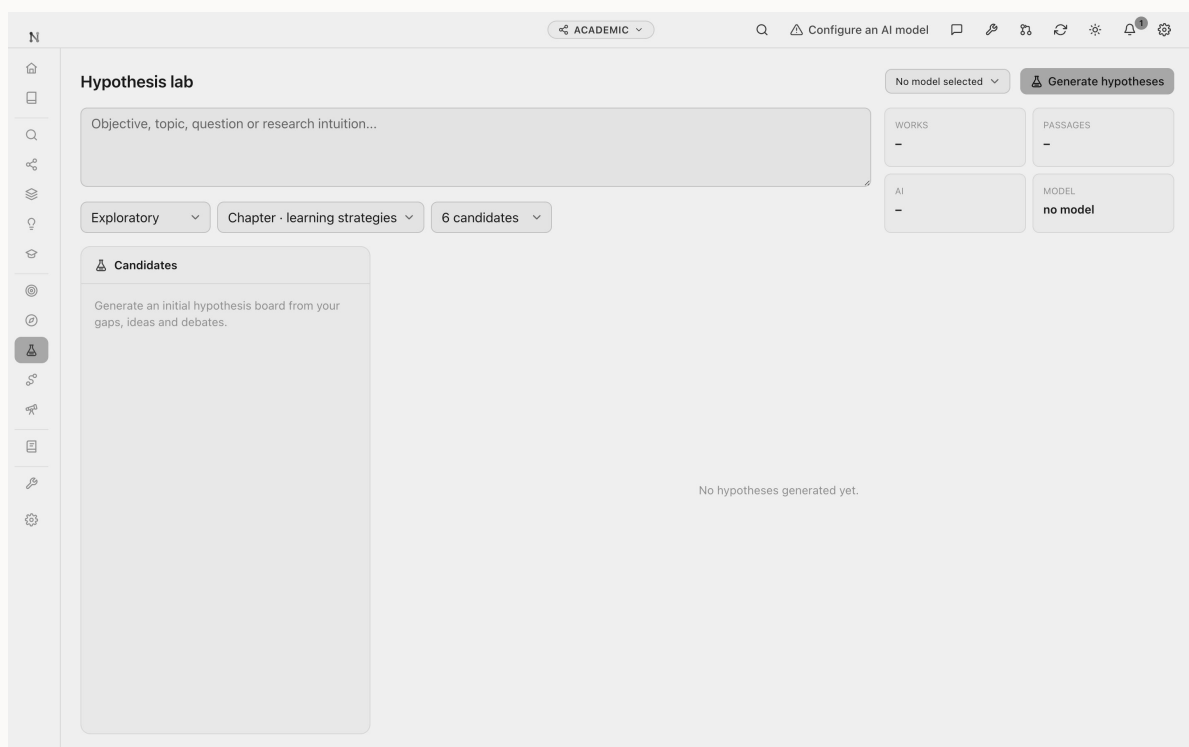
Academic Research vault → Hypotheses

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a hypothesis from a documented pattern or unresolved debate.
2. Attach supporting and contradicting ideas.
3. Write a result that would falsify it and outline the minimum viable test.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A useful hypothesis can fail; avoid wording that explains every possible outcome.



Hypotheses in the Nodus desktop application

ANALYSE

13 Reading paths

Order sources and ideas into a purposeful route through the corpus.

A reading path can introduce foundations, move through a debate and finish with open questions. Each stop should have a reason, not simply a rank.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Academic Research vault → Reading paths

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a learning or research objective.
2. Sequence foundational, contrasting and advanced sources.
3. Add a short purpose to each stop and revise the path as the corpus changes.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep paths short enough to finish; branch optional depth instead of making one endless list.

ANALYSE

14 Deep Research

Generate a long-form, citation-rich report from the whole scoped corpus.

Deep Research runs as a queued job, synthesises selected material and produces a structured report whose citations can be opened. It should be treated as an auditable draft.

WHERE TO FIND IT

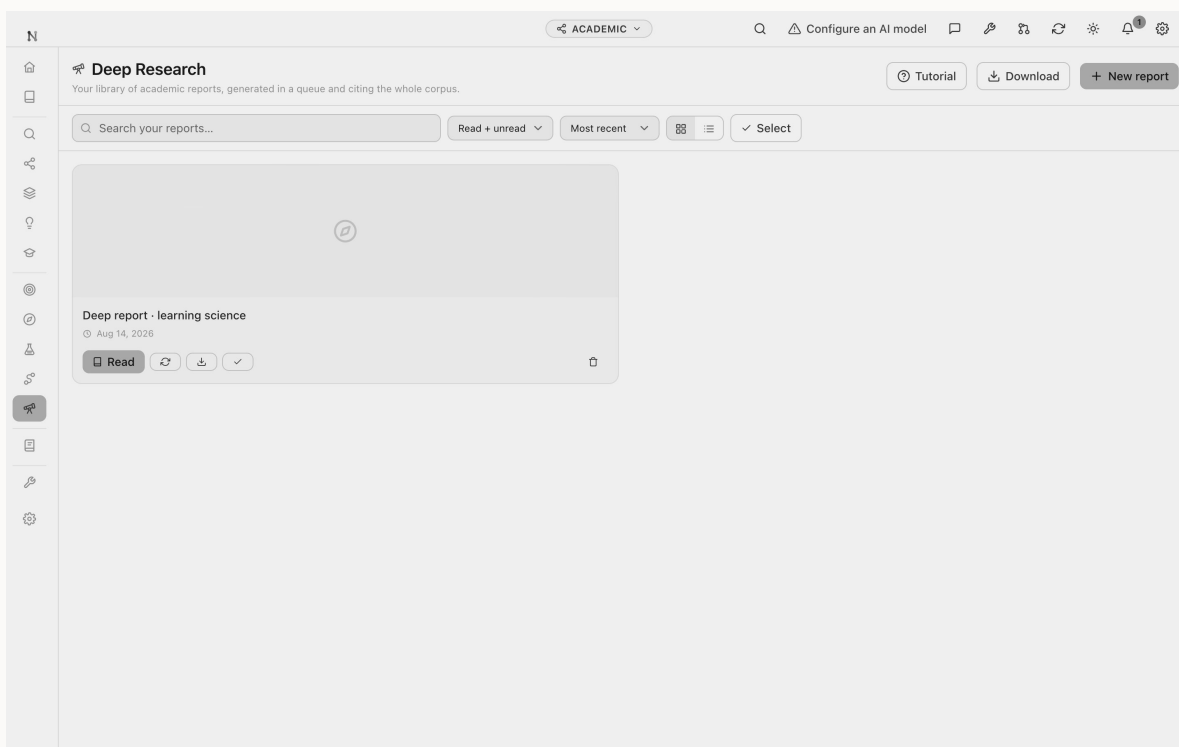
Academic Research vault → Deep Research

STEP BY STEP

1. Write a bounded question, choose the corpus scope and start the job.
2. Monitor the queue and open the report when processing completes.
3. Audit important claims through their citations, annotate problems and export only after review.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A precise question and curated scope matter more than maximum corpus size.



Deep Research in the Nodus desktop application

WRITE

15 Workspace, projects and notes

Develop manuscripts and source-linked notes in one project workspace.

Workspace is the current home for projects, drafts and supporting notes. It keeps early observations close to their sources, then lets mature material move into a structured manuscript without losing provenance.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Academic Research vault → Workspace, projects and notes

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Workspace and create a project for the paper, chapter or review.
2. Create notes with descriptive titles and link each observation to its relevant source or idea.
3. Organise the project outline, move reviewed material into the draft and verify every citation before export.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Separate source notes, synthesis notes and final prose so their evidential status stays clear.

CONFIGURE

16 Academic settings

Control Zotero, extraction, graph behaviour, models, Word, MCP and backups.

Academic settings expose the common provider and system controls plus research-specific integrations and extraction preferences.

WHERE TO FIND IT

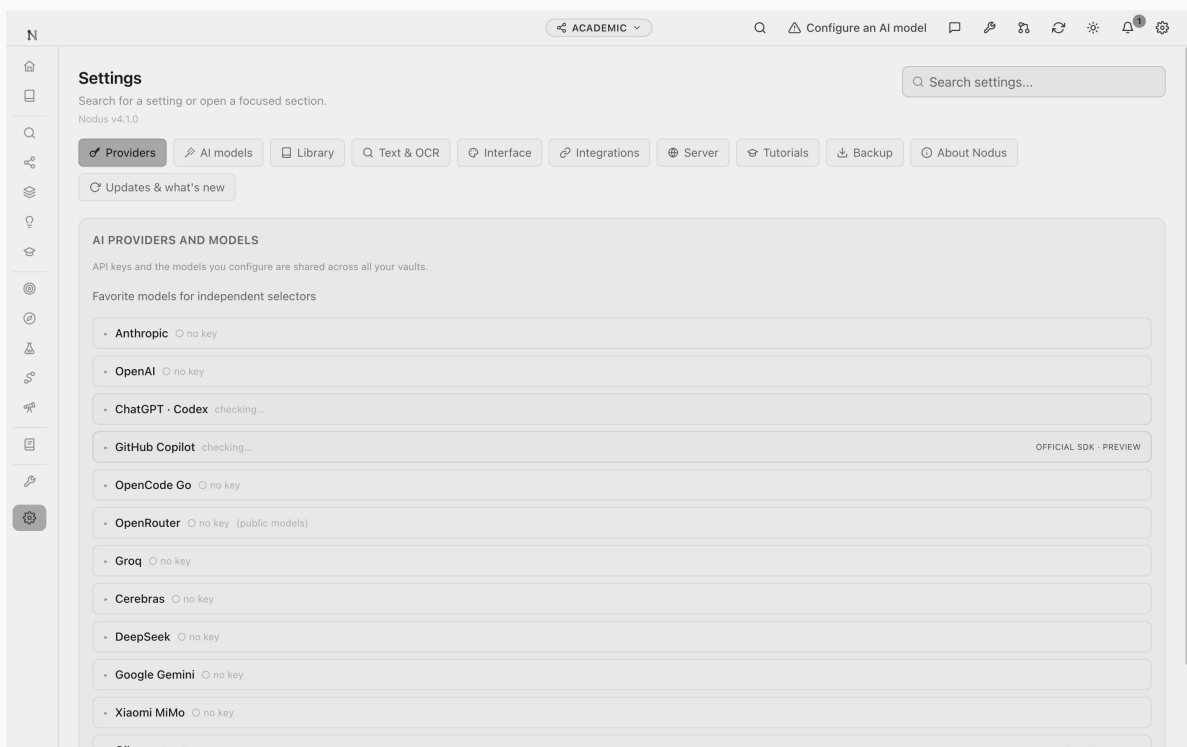
Academic Research vault → Academic settings

STEP BY STEP

1. Configure Zotero or direct imports and verify Library status.
2. Review text extraction, OCR, citation style and per-task model choices.
3. Enable Word, MCP or publishing only when needed, then verify backup health.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Change one pipeline setting at a time and test it on a known source.



Academic settings in the Nodus desktop application

REFERENCE

Completion checklist

- The vault scope and name match the project.
- Sources or records have preserved originals and reviewed metadata.
- Generated interpretations have been checked against their evidence.
- Optional providers and integrations use only the intended data.
- Exports have been proofread in their final format.
- A recent backup has been created and verified.

This manual documents the desktop workflow represented in Nodus 4.1. Interface details may evolve between releases; the in-app privacy notice and release notes govern the exact behaviour of the installed version.